> Such a resounding chorus of prayer rose from the earth
> That in heaven they asked Jesus what all the clamour was . . .[86]

Akbar soon proved himself the adversary the British had always feared he would be. Within a few days he had transformed the uprising by blockading the cantonment effectively for the first time. Mullahs were sent into all the villages in the vicinity to stop the farmers selling the British supplies.[87] The villages to the rear were occupied and garrisoned, and the headmen threatened with instant death if they sold a single sack of grain or fodder to the Firangis. The new wooden bridge over the Kabul River which linked the cantonment with the Bala Hisar and the Jalalabad road was burned down. To Macnaghten's anger, the garrison made no attempt to stop the destruction, and merely watched idly from the behind their parapets, even though the Afghans dismantling bridge were easily within range. With two of the leading Royalist leaders killed on the heights of Bibi Mahru, the previously somewhat fractured rebel command now united firmly around Akbar Khan and his Barakzais. 'It is perfectly wonderful how they [the rebels] hang together,' wrote a frustrated Macnaghten.[88]

Akbar Khan's marriage alliance with the daughter of Mohammad Shah Khan, one of the most powerful Ghilzai chieftains, also began to change the ethnicity of the resistance. With Abdullah Khan Achakzai dead and the Kohistani Tajiks increasingly sidelined following the death of Mir Masjidi and the departure of his followers en masse to bury their Pir, it was the unsophisticated but formidable Ghilzai who now came to dominate the uprising. Basing themselves in the fort of Mahmud Khan just outside the city walls, it was their troops who increasingly filled the ranks of men ringing the hilltops around the silent and cowed cantonment, supported by the Barakzai forces who had made their base in the Shah Bagh at the valley bottom.

Within the cantonment walls, the pressure was now intense as icy blizzards and hunger brought morale ever lower. The horses were so hungry they were found gnawing at tent pegs and eating their own dung over and over again; Lady Sale saw one starving horse bite off and devour the tail of its neighbour, while her own mare champed away at a cart wheel. Mirza 'Ata, like many Afghans, relished the discomfiture of the once arrogant British. 'It now happened that so much snow fell that the English troops, who had never seen the snows of Khurasan, became like melting